7 STEPS TO SUCCESS
In Deen & Dunya

for Muslim Entrepreneurs,
Professionals, & Seekers

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STEP 1 ~ PURPOSE

We did not create the heavens and the earth and everything in between without purpose.

Quran 21:16

If I ask you a simple question 'How is life?', what would your answer be? Usually, there tend to be two different types of answers. Some of you say, 'Life is tough. Life is unfair. Life is cruel.' Others say, 'Life is beautiful. Life is amazing. Life is the best gift.'

Most of the time, the only difference between these groups of people is that the second group discovered their purpose in life and lived it.

He who has a why to live for can bear with almost any how.

– Nietzsche

I have been on both ends. Growing up, life was tough. Later on, I studied and got a job. Life got easier in a materialistic sense. However, until I found out my why and followed that path, I was not truly experiencing life to the fullest.

Have you ever wondered?

Have you ever wondered: Who am I? Why am I here? What's the purpose of life? What am I supposed to do here? Is there a life after death? Why is there so much suffering in this world?

The two most important days in your life are the day you are born and the day you find out why.

– Mark Twain

In this book, I will share my journey of how I discovered answers to these questions. Hopefully, you will benefit, inshaAllah.

I could have written this book in a way that proclaims, "This is the Truth. It's my way or the highway!" But as I get older, I realize that we humans are not rational but rather emotional beings.

Universe is the greatest love poem ever being written…

What verse are you? What metaphor are you?

What do you mean?

– Amir Sulaiman

With that in mind, I have decided to write this book as if I am talking to a friend sharing my story instead of preaching. That's how I'm most comfortable connecting with others anyway. So there will be more questions than answers. There will be dialogues. You are welcome to question everything you read on these pages. If you come across a better answer, please, share it with me.

Thank you for being here. Thank you for being open-minded and open-hearted.

Another rags-to-riches story?

I also could have framed this as a rags-to-riches story about yet another multi-millionaire (at least on paper). But it would be misleading. Now that I am in my 40s and looking back and connecting the dots, I clearly see The Guide guiding me all along the way, alhamdulillah.

So, in a way, this is His story–the one that Allah SWT wrote and that I am grateful to be a part of. That's why I'm so excited about the story He is writing in your life too.

STEP 2 ~ PASSION

"You've got to find what you love. The only way to do great work is to love what you do. If you haven't found it yet, keep looking. Don't settle. As with all matters of the heart, you'll know when you find it."

—Steve Jobs, Co-founder of Apple Inc.

Do you like your life movie? Are you the main hero? Do you love what you do? Do you do what you love so it doesn't feel like work or a job? Are you great at what you do so you feel confident and others look up to you? What about helping others? Does your work create so much impact in others' lives that it is so fulfilling? Do you get paid well by doing what you love?

Flow is being completely involved in an activity for its own sake. The ego falls away. Time flies. Every action, movement, and thought follows inevitably from the previous one...

—Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi

Today, I can truly say that I love what I do. Alhamdulillah, I am good at what I do and I am getting better every day. My team and I serve millions of Muslims by helping Muslim Entrepreneurs and Professionals. We get paid well, alhamdulillah.

However, it was not always like this. If you asked me these questions 20 years ago, I would reply to you not to waste my time.

The Question I Hated The Most

You see, years ago I was in a different state: survival mode. Have you been there before? Are you there now?

This may sound familiar: I did everything I could legally do in order to earn money. Growing up in poverty in a single-parent household had a long-lasting impact.

As a child, the question I hated the most was: "What is your favorite color?" It is not that I didn't understand the question. I did. Let's say you have a blue pen, red pen, and green pen. With those three pens in front of you, the questions "What is your favorite color? Which one do you like better?" are easy.

My problem was: I didn't have a pen at all. Not a blue one, a red one, or a green one. So when you presented a pen to me, it didn't matter what color it was. I would take any pen with any color.

The moral of the story is that you can't think about passion when you are in survival mode. It is a luxury.

Fast forward to today, and I know my favorite color. I know even the favorite colors of my kids. What changed? Now I can afford to buy things for myself and my family. They have options. They have a choice.

Money-Driven Only

Most people live just in the pursuit of money. In my first 10 years abroad in Denmark, I got a house, a car, and a well-paid job, alhamdulillah. But as I said earlier, something was missing.

We need money only to a certain point, but then it has a lesser and lesser effect on the quality of our lives. If you are

Chapter Three explains more about the next step we needed to take. For now, however, let's review what we learned in this chapter through the next set of action steps.

Action Steps for Step 2 (Passion)

1. Ask Allah to guide you and help you to discover your purpose and passion, so you can best serve Him.
2. Write down your reflections on the four ikigai elements:

- What you love (things that put you in a flow state)
- What the world needs (your mission)
- What you are good at (your skills, talents)
- What you can earn an income from (get paid)

Be sure to do each action step carefully, especially step two. Don't rush through this step; you may want to ask a spouse or close friend, or family member to help you with some options here if they do not come to you easily. Try to aim for a minimum of three items for each element, but more items are preferred. This will give you plenty of ideas to work with as we expound upon them later.

STEP 5 ~ PURCHASE

Who is the world's best salesman, past or present? The answer might surprise you. We will get to that in a bit. However, let's learn more about the basics of Sales first.

The fifth of the seven key steps on your journey is Purchase, also known as sales. After learning how to talk about the product you are passionate about, it's time to plan your purchase. This just means how you will offer your product or service to consumers.

Sales is another sadly misunderstood stage of business, marred by the cheesy, aggressive, and tricky tactics that too many sellers have used throughout time. There is a famous saying, "Nobody likes to be sold, but they like to buy." This is absolutely true. People have to buy many things, but they rightfully do not like to be treated poorly by sellers.

As Deenpreneurs, we need to reorient ourselves away from negative or improper ways of selling and learn how to sell with professionalism and integrity.

Ready to Sell?

Hopefully, you have begun addressing your free marketing channels to tell them the story of what you are doing, but

more importantly, why you are doing it. Your circles will begin to better know who you are and why they should join your journey.

But if you put in all this effort, learning and creating so much work, and then you do absolutely nothing with it beyond your small circles, it would be a waste. There would be no forward momentum of the value you have created. This is where the significance of purchase (also called sales) comes into play, and it is one of the core pillars of any business.

If this purchase stage doesn't happen, value doesn't exchange hands. You will not be paid. Your teammates will not be able to get paid. You will not have the funds to grow your business. And your customers also don't get to be served by your purpose and passion!

The blood supply of any business is money. To be worthy of receiving that blood, you must believe and be able to prove that you are selling the solution to a problem better than anybody else.

Suppose you have created something unique, something so phenomenal that it actually changes how things have been done. Doesn't it become like an obligation and responsibility on your shoulders to get it to as many people as possible? There is a trust (amanah) to pushing forward with all the blessings you have already received in your entrepreneurial experience.

Why do people buy?

The story you have identified and learned to tell in promotion is now ready to be broadcasted to people who are willing to give you their hard-earned money. Money is a storage of value. Sales happen when you prove the value of your offer; the consumer recognizes the value and agrees to exchange money for your product.

PEACE

What do we all want in life? What is success? What is true happiness? What is joy? What is peace?

This is the last chapter of the book. We went through the journey together to come to this point. Typically, you will be in one of these three situations by now.

1. **You made it! Mabrook!**

   You discovered your Purpose and Passion then turned it into a Product (or joined a team) that solves a problem for people. Then you Promoted it. They Purchased it. Your product delivered its Promise. You live in Prosperity. You make a great living doing what you love. You provide for your family. You share your wealth with your community and those who are needy and the orphans as well. If this is the case, may Allah bless your journey and your story even more. Please, reach out to me via email: salam@halal.ad. Maybe, we will invite you to our podcast to share your story, iA.

2. **You are on your way.**

   You have started on your journey. You have come through some steps. You are not quite there yet. It is ok. May Allah (SWT) keep you consistent on your journey. If you need help beyond this book, visit www.deenpreneurs.net/journey to learn more. I also offer group coaching or 1 on 1 help.

3. **You have not started yet.**

   Maybe you read the book just to entertain yourself. It is ok if this is what you want. Maybe you don't believe it will work. Maybe you don't believe that it will work for you. Maybe you are afraid that you will try and you will fail again. I completely understand. I have been

there many times. Maybe you worry too much as I did. What do other people think? What if I start but do not finish again?

If you're in the third category, don't give up hope yet. Keep reading.

I want to share with you that one thing I realized that really changed how I started looking at everything is that we modern human beings think too much about ourselves. I do this. I do that. I… I… I…

Fear of Flight

Let me share one last personal story with you, about a fear I developed of flying on airplanes. In the beginning, I didn't mind flying. After a while, maybe once I became a father or maybe once I started establishing myself and gained wealth, I started to become anxious whenever I flew on airplanes. I would sit on the plane hoping that the flight would end as soon as possible. Seconds turned into minutes. Minutes turned into hours. Hours felt like days. It felt like any minute, the plane would fall down. My life would be over.

I would try to watch movies to kill time. I would try to think of anything else except the fact that I was flying a plane. I would do anything. But the reality would always kick in. The loud sound of the plane engine would remind me of where I was, over and over.

But we can only worry to a certain extent. At some point, I had to make a decision. I could either keep avoiding the biggest elephant in the room and keep doing this to myself or talk to the elephant. Flying a plane could become a bigger nightmare, or I could face my fear once and for all.

So I started asking questions: Why am I so afraid of flying? What bothers me so much?

The answer came back fast. I was afraid of a plane crash.